

You keep waiting for a gap that never opens

8 findings · 11-step checklist · 1 myth · 5 sources · cheatgrid.com

You're not slower than everyone else. The gap you're waiting for barely exists: fast group talk runs on near-overlap, not silence, so holding out for a clean pause **just means you keep missing your moment**.

THE GOAL

You're trying to get your point in before the moment closes, by shaping it while they're still talking, not after they stop.

CHECKLIST

You're in a fast, multi-person conversation with something you want to add, and you can feel the moment for it slipping past.

- ☐ Start shaping your first few words as soon as you feel the point forming, while they're still talking, not after they stop.
- ☐ If the conversation has already moved past your point, trim what you say down to where things are now.
- ☐ Catch whether they're asking, claiming, or telling you to do something as they start, to size up how far they've got to go.
- ☐ When you're near the tail end of what they're saying, speak into it: a short overlap right there doesn't land as cutting them off.
- ☐ Repeat a couple of their own words back (their last phrase works) to claim the floor before you're fully ready with yours.
- ☐ If what you've got is only a few words long, say it anyway: a few words is a normal turn here, not a stall.
- ☐ If your point rests on one detail (a number, a name, a date), say that detail first in case you're cut off before the rest.
- ☐ If you and someone else start speaking at the same instant, keep going instead of pulling back straight away.
- ☐ If someone else keeps the floor instead of you, hold your point and watch for the next place it fits, rather than starting over.
- ☐ Once you've said it, stop there: don't repeat it or add a second version to make sure it landed.
- ☐ If it doesn't land this time, pick one exact place to bring it back in (a name, a subtopic) instead of reopening the whole conversation.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 The pause you're waiting for barely exists, and waiting for it is what keeps costing you the opening.
- 2 In a natural-conversation study, adding a third speaker sped up the gap only in turns where people were competing to jump in, not because you're any slower.
- 3 The reason you wait is that it feels safer: staying quiet means nobody can blame you for cutting them off.

The pause you're waiting for

KNOW

The pause you're waiting for barely exists, and waiting for it is what keeps costing you the opening.

The real average gap between turns is about 200 milliseconds, **too quick to plan in**, so you must already be forming your reply while talking. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

In a natural-conversation study, adding a third speaker sped up the gap only in turns where people were competing to jump in, not because you're any slower.

In those competitive turns, a third speaker's fastest response is what gets timed, so the recorded gap shrinks even without anyone reacting quicker. [Source 5](#)

DO

You don't get to wait until they stop to start thinking.

Getting a word in means guessing where the sentence is heading and shaping your reply while you're still listening, not after they stop. [Source 2](#)

What a turn doesn't require

KNOW

What you add doesn't have to answer the last thing said. People in real recorded conversation often build on their own point instead of replying to whoever just spoke, and that's completely ordinary.

Each speaker often carries their own thought forward instead of reacting to the other person's last line. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

You don't need a full thought ready either. In recorded natural conversation, people's turns often run just a few words, shorter than the time your brain needs to plan a fresh word from scratch.

A turn that short leaves no time to plan a whole reply in advance, so people say a few words and keep going from there. [Source 3](#)

Getting in without waiting for silence

WATCH

The reason you wait is that it feels safer: staying quiet means nobody can blame you for cutting them off.

But a short overlap right at the end of their sentence **doesn't read as cutting them off** at all: only overlap starting mid-turn does. [Source 4](#)

WATCH

You can guess how much is left in someone's turn before they finish it. Whether what they're saying sounds like a question, a statement, or an instruction hints at how much more is coming, before you've heard the specific words.

Knowing early which kind of sentence it is narrows down the shape of what's still coming, even before the exact words arrive. [Source 2](#)

SAY

Echo a few of their own words back before you finish your thought, something like "Wait, the budget thing..." to buy yourself a beat while you shape the rest.

Referencing a few of their own words is one of the ways speakers already buy themselves time to finish forming what they're about to say. [Source 1](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

The polite thing to do is wait until the other person has completely finished talking before you say anything.

ACTUALLY

That's not how conversation works. Listeners in a controlled study did not rate a short overlap right at the end of someone's sentence as **an interruption at all**, only a longer overlap that started in the middle of their point. [Source 4](#)

Sources

1. <https://www.mpg.de/language>
2. <https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/psychology/articles/10.3389/fpsyg.2015.00751/full>
3. https://eprints.whiterose.ac.uk/id/eprint/222710/2/PingPong_Manuscript_revision_FINAL18Jan22.pdf

4. https://stacks.stanford.edu/file/druid:vf660gm5432/Hilton_2018_What_Does_An_Interruption_Sound_Like-augmented.pdf
5. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC8481383/>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Speaking up in a group at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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